

HR-204 Flexible Working

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Effective Date: 1 January 2026 Owner: People Operations

Applies to: All employees with at least twenty-six weeks of service

1 Purpose and Scope

This policy explains what flexible working means, who may apply, and how to make a request for a flexible working arrangement. It covers permanent changes to contractual terms, not occasional informal adjustments, which an employee should simply agree with their manager.

2 Forms of Flexible Working

A flexible working arrangement may involve any of the following changes.

- Part-time hours, or a reduction in contracted weekly hours
- Compressed hours, where full-time hours are worked over fewer days
- Flexitime, where start and finish times vary around agreed core hours
- Term-time working, or an annualised hours arrangement
- Job sharing between two employees
- A change to the employee's contractual place of work

A request to work remotely on a regular basis is handled under the remote and hybrid working policy, reference HR-207, unless the employee is asking to change their contractual place of work permanently.

3 Eligibility

Any employee with at least twenty-six weeks of continuous service may make a flexible working request.

An employee may make up to two requests in any period of twelve months, and no reason for the request needs to be given.

4 Making a Request

4.1 Informal Arrangements

Where an employee needs a short-term or occasional adjustment, they should discuss it with their manager rather than making a formal request. Informal arrangements do not change contractual terms and may be withdrawn by either party with reasonable notice.

4.2 Requesting a Flexible Working Arrangement

A formal request for flexible working must be made in writing through the human resources system. The request must state the change the employee is asking for, the date on which they would like it to start, whether they have made a previous request and when, and what effect they think the change would have on their team and how that effect could be managed.

The manager will arrange a meeting to discuss the request within twenty-eight calendar days of receiving it. The employee may be accompanied to that meeting by a colleague or a trade union representative.

The manager must give a written decision within two months of the original request, including any period of appeal.

Where a request is approved, People Operations issues a written variation to the employee's contract of employment confirming the new arrangement and its start date. Where a request is declined, the written decision must state which of the business grounds in section five applies and explain the reasoning.

An employee may appeal a declined request in writing within fourteen calendar days of the decision. The appeal is heard by a manager who was not involved in the original decision.

4.3 Trial Periods

A manager may approve a request on a trial basis for a defined period of up to three months before confirming a permanent change. The trial and its review date must be confirmed in writing at the outset.

5 Grounds for Declining a Request

A request may only be declined for one or more of the following reasons.

- The burden of additional costs would be unreasonable
- The change would have a detrimental effect on meeting customer demand
- Work cannot be reorganised among existing staff
- Additional staff cannot be recruited to cover the work
- Quality or performance would suffer to a material degree
- There is insufficient work during the hours the employee wishes to work
- The change conflicts with planned structural changes to the business

6 Records

Requests, decisions, and appeal outcomes are recorded in the human resources system and retained for three years.